

New Year's Resolutions
You Can Actually Keep



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What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Fed Chair Jerome Powell** is trying to avoid appearing confrontational with Donald Trump, even though some of his colleagues are signaling unease that the president-elect's policies might rekindle inflationary pressures. **A1**
- ◆ **A fall in shares** of big tech companies dragged U.S. stocks lower on Friday. The Dow, S&P 500 and Nasdaq fell 0.8%, 1.1% and 1.5%, respectively. The yield on the benchmark 10-year Treasury settled at 4.619%. **B10**
- ◆ **Do Kwon, whose TerraUSD and Luna cryptocurrencies** collapsed in a \$40 billion crash in 2022, should be extradited to the U.S. rather than his native South Korea, according to Montenegro's justice ministry. **A3**
- ◆ **Hedge funds and other money managers** have piled into Argentine markets this year, putting Buenos Aires stocks on pace to finish 2024 as the world's best performers and causing government bond prices to soar. **B10**
- ◆ **China sanctioned seven companies** in response to recent U.S. announcements of military sales and aid to Taiwan, which Beijing claims as its territory. **A7**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Jetliners being accidentally blasted out of the sky** has become the leading cause of commercial-aviation deaths in recent years—a new trend that runs counter to an otherwise improving safety picture. **A1**
- ◆ **Azerbaijan Airlines said** “physical and technical external interference” caused the crash that killed 38 people flying to southern Russia. **A5**
- ◆ **Donald Trump asked** the Supreme Court to stop a federal law banning TikTok from taking effect next month, saying he wants to pursue a negotiated resolution. **A4**
- ◆ **Treasury Secretary Yellen** said the U.S. will hit its borrowing limit in the middle of next month, triggering “extraordinary measures” to keep the government from defaulting on its obligations. **A4**
- ◆ **Trump's team is looking** at using military bases to detain migrants and military planes to boost deportations, incoming border czar Tom Homan said. **A3**
- ◆ **South Korea's legislature** voted to impeach acting President Han Duck-soo, after he declined to make judicial appointments needed to advance the impeachment of his predecessor. **A6**
- ◆ **Iran has detained one of Italy's best-known journalists**, raising fears that Iranian authorities might be holding her as leverage in dealings with the West. **A7**
- ◆ **Died: Greg Gumbel**, 78, CBS sportscaster. **A2** ... **Osamu Suzuki**, 94, longtime Suzuki Motor head. **B10**

NOONAN

The president who wasn't there **A13**

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The Sky's the Limit at Balloon Festival in Nepal



UP, UP AND AWAY: The Rat Cheese balloon, from Brazil, rose in the sky Friday with snowy Himalayan peaks as a backdrop during the International Hot Air Balloon Festival in Pokhara, Nepal, the country's first time hosting a hot-air balloon event.

Thune Faces Delicate Task Leading a Fractured Senate

By MOLLY BALL

Sen. John Thune had a little more than three hours to bask in his big victory before Donald Trump dropped an anvil on his head.

At midday on Nov. 13, Thune's Republican Senate colleagues elected him majority leader, the triumphant capstone to his decades in public

life. Just after 3:30 p.m., Trump announced he planned to nominate Matt Gaetz, the polarizing Florida congressman, to be his attorney general—sending GOP senators into a tizzy over the scandal-plagued choice.

“Well, this is going to be a tough one,” Thune said with a chuckle, recalling what went through his mind at the time.

The 63-year-old South Dakotan's lanky figure was splayed across a blue brocade armchair in his office in the Capitol as the barren winter landscape cast a cold light. “You’re just reminded,” he reflected further, “of how challenging the job is going to be.”

Thune took it in stride, as he does most things. The genial 20-year veteran of the

Senate is preternaturally even-keeled and difficult to rattle—qualities he will undoubtedly need in the months to come. The recent shutdown drama put a spotlight on the fractious House. But the Senate—where it will fall to Thune to manage

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◆ **Slim House lead is hurdle for GOP** **A4**

Missiles Are Now Biggest Killer Of Fliers

Passenger flights have become very safe—except when they go near conflicts

By DANIEL MICHAELS
AND BENJAMIN KATZ

Jetliners being accidentally blasted out of the sky has become the leading cause of commercial-aviation deaths in recent years—a new trend that runs counter to an otherwise improving safety picture.

The crash Wednesday of an Azerbaijan Airlines jetliner in Kazakhstan, if officially confirmed as a shootdown, would be the third major fatal downing of a passenger jet linked to armed conflict since 2014, according to the Flight Safety Foundation's Aviation Safety Network, a global database of accidents and incidents. The tally would bring to more than 500 the number of deaths from such attacks during that time.

Preliminary results of Azerbaijan's investigation into the crash indicate the plane was hit by a Russian anti-aircraft missile, or shrapnel from it, said people briefed on the probe.

“It adds to the worrying catalog of shootdowns now,” said Andy Blackwell, an aviation risk adviser at security specialist ISARR and former head of security at Virgin Atlantic. “You’ve got the conventional

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◆ **‘External interference’ is blamed in plane crash....** **A5**

The Fed Tries Again To Size Up Trump

By NICK TIMIRAOS

Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell is walking an old tightrope into 2025: He is trying to avoid appearing confrontational with Donald Trump, even though some of his colleagues are signaling unease that the president-elect's policies might rekindle inflationary pressures.

The difficult balancing act was on full display over the last two months. In early November, days after Trump's election to a second term as president, Powell declared that the central bank wouldn't set interest rates based on assumptions or speculation about the incoming administration's policies, including possibly transformative changes to trade and immigration policy.

“We don't guess, we don't speculate, and we don't assume,” Powell said at a Nov. 7 news conference.

But the central bank also often says its interest-rate policies need to be “forward looking”—taking into account projections of future price pressures and employment conditions—because it takes time for changes in borrowing costs to filter through the economy.

The Fed cut rates by a quarter point last week, bringing its policy rate down by a full percentage point since September. But new projec-

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◆ **Yellen says U.S. to hit debt ceiling next month.....** **A4**

Germany Reconsiders Its Open Door for Migrants

Even before the recent Christmas market attack, the nation was struggling to cope with influx; economy needs new workers

By BERTRAND BENOIT

SUHL, Germany—Ten years ago, this town in central Germany was aging, rapidly depopulating and almost universally white. Today, its population has stabilized, is younger and includes people from 92 countries.

Some longtime residents have welcomed the change, but for many others, it's happening too fast. In May, conservative Mayor André Knapp was re-elected with more than 82% of the votes after a campaign critical of immigration, which he blamed for a rise in local crime. In September, the Alternative for Germany, or AfD, a far-right party that advocates mass deportations, won its first state

election in Thuringia, where Suhl is located.

“Of course we need immigration, we need foreign workers, but we can't have a situation where our town is getting completely overwhelmed,” said Knapp.

Many Western countries are rethinking their immigration policies and how open they want to be, even as they grapple with the effects of low birthrates and aging populations. U.S. President-elect Donald Trump made restricting immigration, including mass deportations, a central pitch in his campaign.

Countries including Canada, Sweden, Denmark and the Netherlands have tightened controls, citing costs, popular pressure and

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The Meaning Of Reading? Up for Debate

Book purists say audiobook fans don't measure up

By JEFFREY A. TRACHTENBERG

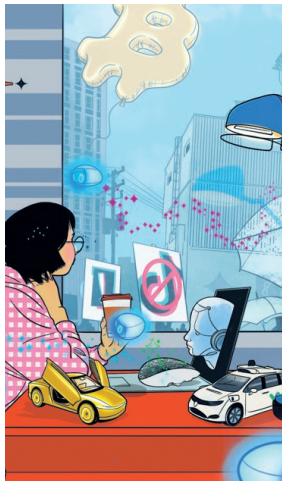
Brittany Lowry has devoured more than 80 books this year. The twist? The social-media creator in Alberta, Canada, hasn't read a word.

“I count them as books I've read,” Lowry, 34, said of her audiobook consumption. “Who doesn't want to slay a dragon while washing the dishes?”

Publishers are grappling

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EXCHANGE



INTO THE FUTURE
The tech that will change your life in the coming year **B1**

What Your ‘Face Age’ Reveals About Health

By ALEX JANIN

Cancer doctor Raymond Mak had a hunch that an elderly patient was healthy enough to withstand aggressive treatment. A photo of the man's face helped affirm his intuition.

Mak ran the photo through a “face age” test, which showed that the 90-year-old man's health was more similar to someone in their late 60s.

The FaceAge test is an artificial intelligence model trained on tens of thousands of photos from patients and public-image databases to look for signs of aging in the face.

Mak and his team ran a study that found that the algo-

rithm did a better job than doctors at predicting how long cancer patients would live.

Their hope is that one day, the tool could be a standard part of assessing health. Already, separate versions of face-age tests exist online where anybody can upload a selfie and get an estimate of their biological age.

“Your face reflects the wear and tear of your lifetime,” says Mak, a radiation oncologist at Brigham and Women's Hospital, who co-led the study alongside other Mass General Brigham researchers. “We viewed this as a way to quantify a doctor's clinical intuition.”

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Homeless Number Soars

The rise is fueled by several factors, HUD officials say. **A2**

